UNIQUE MARKETING ISSUES · ENTREPRENEURSHIP

Found, chosen, *booked.*

How an entrepreneurial guesthouse finds its guests, when AI does the searching.

PRESENTED BY
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FOR
Lecturer selection

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No. 01

CASE STUDY

Ruka Maldives, Dhiffushi, North Malé Atoll. A real twelve-room guesthouse, used with the owner's permission.

THE CASE

The Ruka Maldives *dilemma*

PROPERTY	Ruka Maldives
LOCATION	Dhiffushi, North Malé Atoll
SIZE	12 rooms · opened 2025
WEBSITE	*None of its own*

THE AI SEARCH PROBLEM



Hundreds of rooms. The AI shows *three.*

Will Ruka make the list?



abdullamuizfuad.github.io/GEO-Visibility-/demo

YOUR TURN

Be the *traveller.*

01 Scan the code with your camera

02 Choose the traveller you are

03 Watch the AI choose your stay

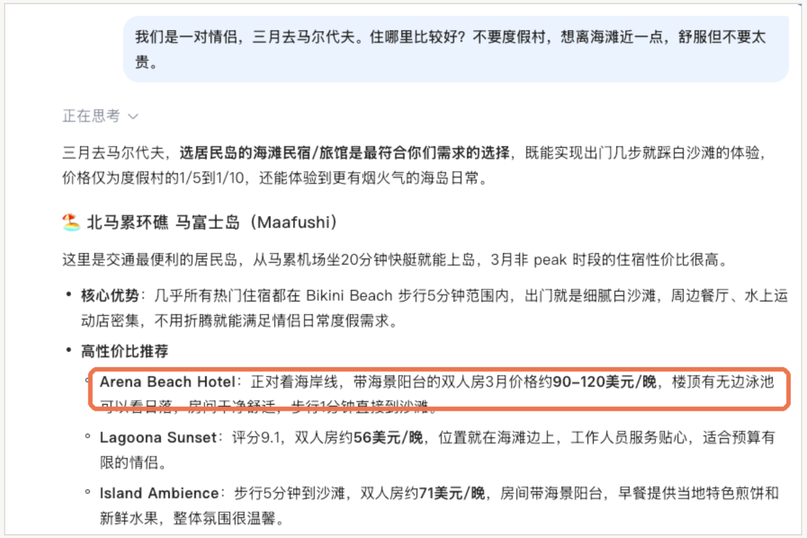
04 Look for Ruka…

> *Pause at the question: "Why do you think the AI left Ruka out?"*

Same questions, *real* AI engines

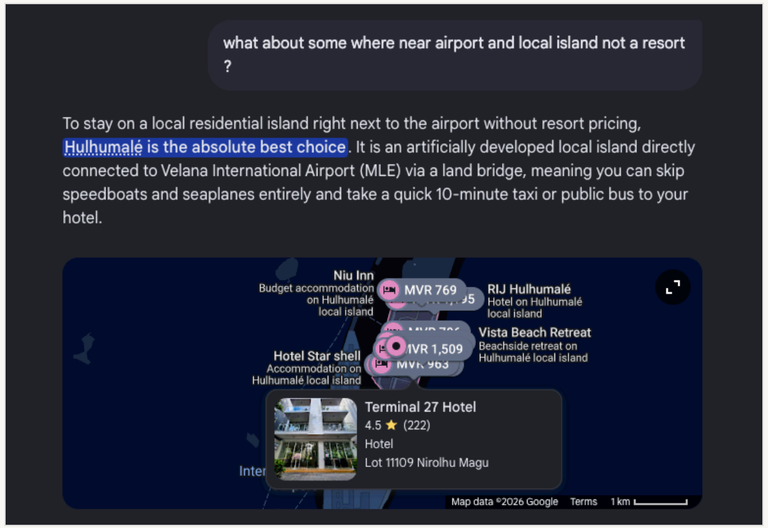
Baidu

In Chinese: “We’re a couple… not a resort, near the beach.”



Google AI Mode

“Near the airport, a local island, not a resort.”



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times Ruka Maldives was named

Arena Beach Hotel: Baidu’s first pick for couples, Gemini’s for families

Dhiffushi recommended, with **Athiri Residence**, not Ruka

Google’s picks all carry a **rating, map pin & website**

Four questions every *venture* must answer

By the end of this session, you can answer each for Ruka.

01

Who?

Segment the market, choose a target and establish a unique position.

02

Why us?

Define a brand, and explain why it matters to an entrepreneurial firm.

03

What & how?

Apply the 4Ps: product, price, place and promotion.

04

Closing the deal

Walk through the seven-step sales process.

OBJECTIVE ONE

Segment, target, *position.*

Three steps entrepreneurial firms use to find the customers they can serve best.

01	**Segment** WHO COULD STAY?	Divers · Families · Beach & kite lovers · Honeymooners · Budget couples
02	**Target** WHO DO WE SERVE BEST?	*Beach & kite-loving couples*, mid-budget, near Malé
03	**Position** WHY US, NOT THEM?	*“The quiet beach guesthouse, steps from Dhiffushi sand.”*

AI LENS

Generative search engines match a traveller’s intent directly to your position, so it must be **specific, provable and consistent everywhere.**

OBJECTIVE TWO

A brand is a promise people, *and AI,* recognise

> A brand is the set of attributes, positive or negative, that people associate with a company.
>
> *Barringer & Ireland, Entrepreneurship*

Trust when you have no track record

Price premium and repeat stays

Difference from look-alike competitors

Recognition by people and machines

A FRACTURED FOOTPRINT		TEACHING SCENARIO
BOOKING SITE	Ruka Inn	+960 7XX 1234
MAP LISTING	Ruka Guest House	no phone
SOCIAL MEDIA	Ruka Maldives	+960 9XX 5678

A UNIFIED FOOTPRINT

Ruka Maldives

Same name, address and phone everywhere, so every review accrues to one brand.

The marketing mix in the *generative* era

01 Product

Hard facts over generic adjectives.

> 12 rooms · steps from the beach · 10 min to Kite Beach · breakfast included

02 Price

Cost-based or **value-based**, with a transparent range and a clear cancellation policy.

03 Place

Direct (own site, phone) versus **intermediaries** (Booking.com, agents). AI assistants are the new booking channel.

04 Promotion

Reviews, social media and word of mouth, plus **GEO**: being chosen by AI answer engines.

OBJECTIVE FOUR

AI opens doors; *you* close the sale

1. **Prospect for leads** — *AI-assisted*
2. **Initial contact** — *AI-assisted*
3. **Qualify the lead** — *AI-assisted*
4. **Sales presentation** — *AI-assisted*
5. **Meet objections** — *Human touch*
6. **Close the sale** — *Human touch*
7. **Follow-up & retention** — *Human touch*

Steps one to four: the AI finds, filters and presents for you. A guest who clicks through arrives pre-qualified.

Steps five to seven: objections, the close and the relationship still belong to the guesthouse.

DISCUSSION

If AI handles steps one to four, how does the role of a Maldivian guesthouse manager change?

Turn to your neighbour. Which touchpoints should stay human, and which can be automated?

Tap “Continue”

YOUR TURN

Now, make Ruka *visible.*

BRAND	One name, address and phone
PRODUCT	Facts, not adjectives
PRICE	A clear range and cancellation terms
PLACE	A bookable channel of its own

AI VISIBILITY — *Strong*

TRAVELLER: A BEACH-LOVING COUPLE

1 *Ruka Maldives*

2 Stone Hotels Dhiffushi

3 Arena Beach Hotel

Picked the dive couple? Ruka still loses to Reveries. That is positioning.

Measuring learning: from memory to *application*

FORMATIVE — *Understand*

Exit ticket

"In one sentence, what is Ruka's position, and can an AI verify it?"

Two minutes, end of class · instant feedback

REMEMBERING

SUMMATIVE — *Apply*

Exam question

A 10-mark short answer mapping the 4Ps and the seven sales steps to island tourism.

Tests all four learning outcomes

AUTHENTIC PROJECT — *Analyse · Create*

AI visibility audit

Groups audit a local guesthouse across ChatGPT, Google and Booking.com, then recommend its position, brand and 4Ps.

Rubric: diagnosis 30 · recommendations 50 · pitch 20

APPLYING IN THE FIELD →

Found. Chosen. *Booked.*

01 Own a specific position

02 Keep the brand consistent everywhere

03 Ground the 4Ps in verifiable facts

04 Let AI handle discovery; people build trust

MY TEACHING PHILOSOPHY

Students learn marketing best by applying theory to live, local challenges. I teach through real Maldivian case studies, interactive prompts and actionable digital tools.

Abdulla Muiz Fuad

Questions?

References & *sources*

Barringer, B. R., & Ireland, R. D. *Entrepreneurship: Successfully launching new ventures*. Pearson. Chapter: Unique marketing issues.

Morand, J.-C., & Schegg, R. (2026). *Be visible to AI: The keys to semantic optimization and GEO for hotels* [White paper]. HES-SO Valais-Wallis. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19109201

Aggarwal, P., et al. (2024). GEO: Generative engine optimization. *Proceedings of the 30th ACM SIGKDD Conference on Knowledge Discovery and Data Mining*.

Ruka Maldives is used with the owner's permission. Ruka, Stone Hotels Dhiffushi, Reveries Diving Village and Arena Beach Hotel are described only with publicly listed facts; the "fractured footprint" is a teaching scenario. The phone demo is a scripted simulation, not a live AI. AI answers were captured on 4 November 2026.